

JDIOBESTEM FOUNDATION Newsletter

JDIOBE QUARTELY STEM NEWSLETTER

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He came home to Jinja with a box of aircraft

At the 3rd Laudato Si' Green Festival, our STEM exhibition put real engineering models into students' hands.



Holy Cross Lake View Senior Secondary School in Wanyange, Jinja, gave over its compound on 11 July for the third Laudato Si' Green Festival, organized by the school's Laudato Si' Club under the Laudato Youth Initiative. The theme was Environmental Conservation for Peace and Sustainable Development.

JdiobeSTEM Foundation was there as a partner, running the STEM practical exhibition. Dr. Muwanika Jdiobe, an aerospace engineer in research and development at Boeing and a STEM educator at Oklahoma State University, set out model aircraft, rockets and vehicles, and invited students to handle them.

Dr. Jdiobe grew up in Jinja. His doctoral research was on unmanned aerial vehicles using ducted counter-rotating propellers – work aimed at making drones quieter and more efficient. A short drive from where he went to school, he spent both days answering

questions about lift, drag, noise, and what an engineer actually does on an ordinary Tuesday morning.

The exhibition was deliberately hands-on. Students picked the models up, turned them over, and asked why a wing is shaped the way it is. Several arrived with their questions already written down. Teachers asked a harder one: how does a school with no laboratory teach any of this?

That is the question we came to answer. Nothing on our table needed mains electricity or an internet connection. The point of a practical exhibition is not the equipment. It is showing that the reasoning is available to anyone willing to measure something, write it down, and try again.

3000 students from 15 schools came through the exhibition. We are following up with the ones who asked about our Research and Science Fair programs.

The festival in numbers:



2023 – the first Green Festival drew more than 1,000 young people.

2025 – the second drew more than 1,700 in person, and more than 4,000 online.

2026 – 11 July, at Wanyange. 3000 participants.

100 trees planted toward the one-million-tree drive.

Science, peace, and a lake that is shrinking

Between the Green Walk and the Mass, the festival asked what a school can actually change.

The day opened with a Green Walk through Wanyange and closed with the Care for Creation Mass, celebrated by Fr. Peter Caxton Mayanja, C.S.C., Provincial of the Congregation of Holy Cross in East Africa. Between the two sat the part of the program that is hardest to photograph: the sustainability dialogues.

Three strands ran at once – science, community, and mental health. That pairing is unusual, and deliberate. A young person who is frightened about the future does not need another lecture on carbon. The festival treated well-being as part of environmental work rather than a separate subject.

Hon. Justine Kasule Lumumba, Uganda's Minister of Information and Communications Technology, spoke about putting artificial intelligence to work in environmental stewardship. Fr. Mayanja returned to storytelling, arguing that ecological awareness travels through stories people recognize, not through figures they have no way of checking.

Sarah Kirikumwino, President of the Laudato Si' Clubs, put it plainly: "We plant trees whose shade we will never sit beneath. We tend the soil that others will harvest."

Around the dialogues, youth-led eco-innovation exhibitions and research showcases filled the compound. The first day had gone to a community clean-up in Wanyange and Bugembe, and to extending the one-million-tree planting drive with Catholic parishes in Busoga.

For us, the useful part was watching which questions students brought back to the STEM table after sitting in a dialogue. They were sharper. Someone who has just heard about wetland encroachment asks a different question about drainage from someone who has not. That is the



argument for holding a science exhibition inside a festival about creation, rather than on its own.

Who made it happen:

Organized by the Laudato Si' Club of Holy Cross Lake View Senior Secondary School, under the Laudato Youth Initiative, based at the John Paul II Justice and Peace Centre, Kampala.

Partners on the ground: Bethany Lands Institute, Foresters HSE Consults, Avail Fruits of Faith Farm, the Congregation of Holy Cross East Africa Province, and JdiobeSTEM-Foundation.

Fr. Prosper Atukwatse, C.S.C. hosted at the school. Vatican News carried the festival in English and Kiswahili. The full program is at laudato-youthinitiative.org.

Certificates, then real work

In the afternoon the school handed out certificates, and the Laudato Youth Initiative launched the Bishop Charles Martin Wamika Moral Formation and Good Use of Technology Legacy Program. A certificate is a beginning. What matters is which clubs are still meeting in November.



The Legacy Program is named for Bishop Charles Martin Wamika, and covers two things the festival kept returning to: moral formation, and using the internet and new technology well. Those belong together. Every student who asked us about drones also asked what stops someone using one badly.

Our own part in what follows is narrow and specific. JdiobeSTEM runs four programs – Research, Science Fair, Scholarships and Mentorship – and the festival left us with a list of students and teachers who want in.

Schools apply on Form JSF/SP/01. Students applying to the Science Fair now do it online. The form asks for a real budget with real prices from real shops, and it needs a signature from the school. We pay no money to schools, and we do not collect guardian consent – the school holds that.

Here is what we will report next quarter: how many of the students we met in Jinja actually submitted a proposal, and how many of those were funded. That number, rather than the attendance figure, is the one worth watching. Anyone can fill a field for two days. The test is what is still standing in a term's time.

Get in touch:

Schools: partnership applications are open all year round.

Students: the Science Fair proposal form is at our website

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